Teaching Statement

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I teach so that students can reason from evidence and use the tools of economics on questions they care about. Since 2020 I have taught at the Lahore University of Management Sciences (LUMS) and, in 2024–25, as Visiting Assistant Professor at Iowa State University, across every level: graduate microeconomic theory, public finance, game theory, development, behavioral economics, economic policy, and introductory and intermediate microeconomics. My evaluations are strongest where my teaching meets my research: in the most recent semester evaluated at LUMS, students rated *Public Finance* 4.9 out of 5 and *Issues in Economic Policy* 4.5 out of 5.

The course I have invested most in is *Public Finance*, taught at LUMS since 2020. Teaching it made a gap obvious: the standard textbooks are excellent, but they assume a state that observes most incomes, implements what it decides, and can take its relationship with citizens for granted, none of which holds where my students live. The empirical literature on taxation and public spending in developing countries is now mature enough to support a coherent undergraduate treatment, so I am writing one. *Public Economics for Developing Countries* is organized around the questions a developing-country state faces (what to provide, whom to support, what to tax, how to collect) under three constraints that run through every chapter: most incomes are unobserved, administrative capacity is scarce, and the citizen–state relationship is itself at stake. Each chapter pairs the theory with an *Evidence Spotlight* on a landmark study, a *Pakistan in Focus* box drawn where possible from my own field research, a data exercise built on published replication packages, and a graded problem bank.

The book is being written in the classroom rather than in advance. In Fall 2026 my *Public Finance* students read the draft chapters as their course text. Each week they submit a one-page memo: the chapter's core idea in their own words, one attempted problem, and their "muddiest point." Class begins from those memos, and the muddiest points go straight into my revision notes. Over the semester every student also develops a research proposal through graded milestones, from a question in week three to a full draft and a peer-discussion round in week fourteen.

Students learn by doing things with the material. When I teach supply and demand, I run a live market in which students buy and sell on private valuations, so that equilibrium is something they have experienced before it is a diagram. I use whiteboard problem-solving, policy debates, group projects, and the occasional film (*A Beautiful Mind* before Nash equilibrium). I also let students use AI openly. My *Public Finance* syllabus states the policy explicitly: use it to brainstorm, draft, and compute; evaluate and take ownership of what it produces; and tell me when it helped. In their evaluations of my policy course, students wrote that the approach let them "learn effective AI use through experience."

In introductory courses at LUMS I use the open-access CORE curriculum, and I have designed new behavioral and policy-oriented electives. Many of my students have been first-generation college attendees, and I was one myself, so I take the advising side of teaching seriously: I have supervised more than ten undergraduate and master's theses in development, behavioral, and experimental economics, and many of those students have gone on to graduate programs or research assistantships. I have also trained Pakistani civil servants in econometrics, extending the same teaching to the institutions I study. A student in my behavioral economics course once wrote that it "restored my faith in economics"; that is the effect I am after. Whatever students go on to do, I want them to leave able to reason from evidence, weigh trade-offs, and question assumptions, including mine.